Two Thousand Years Later, a New Question About the Most Famous Man in History

The consensus says he existed. I have spent a year arguing that the evidence is thinner than that consensus lets on.

By Stan Thomas

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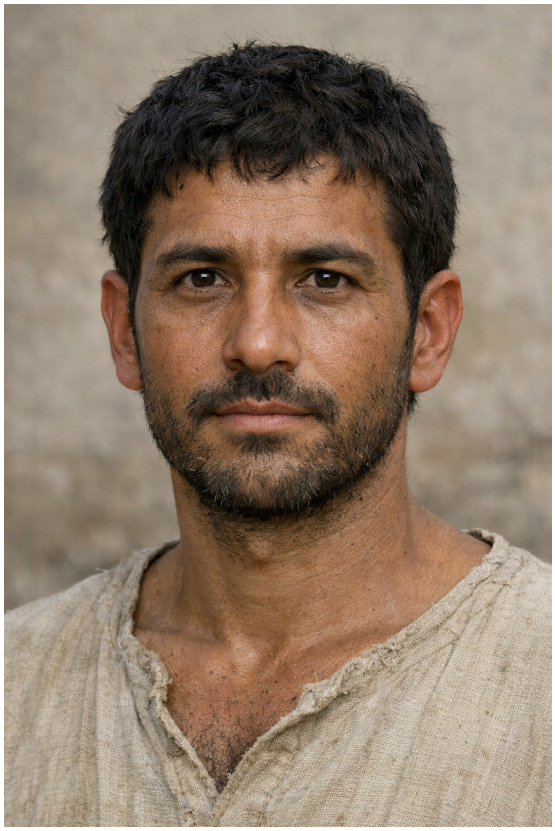

An AI-generated reconstruction of what a first-century Galilean man in his early thirties might plausibly have looked like, informed by ancient DNA studies of Roman-period Judean skeletal remains, forensic anthropology of the region, and the cultural and occupational context of the Jewish artisan class. The image follows the logic of Richard Neave's 2001 forensic reconstruction —that Jesus, if historical, would not have resembled the pale, long-haired figure of European artistic tradition—but is a type study of a first-century Galilean man, not a portrait of any specific historical individual.

I should say first what I am not. I am not a theologian. I do not teach at a divinity school. I do not have a book deal. I live in St. George, Utah, and in my spare time over the past year I have written an 85-page paper arguing that the case for the historical Jesus—the Galilean preacher crucified under Pontius Pilate around the year 30—is considerably weaker than most people, including most scholars, assume.

This is the kind of project that makes serious historians groan before they finish the abstract, and I want to be honest about why that reflex is usually correct. The field has seen this movie before. In the late nineteenth century, a German scholar named Bruno Bauer argued that Jesus was a literary invention; the Dutch Radical school made similar claims a generation later; and more recently, figures like Richard Carrier and Raphael Lataster have made the case in forms that most biblical scholars consider an embarrassment to engage with. Bart Ehrman, the University of North Carolina scholar who is the most prominent secular voice defending the historicity of Jesus, once observed that "virtually every competent scholar of antiquity, Christian or non-Christian, agrees" that Jesus existed.

So why am I adding another paper to what looks like a settled question? The short answer is that I do not actually try to prove Jesus did not exist. I try to prove something narrower, and in some ways more disturbing: that the confidence with which most experts assert his existence is not justified by the evidence they have. That claim, if taken seriously, changes what biblical scholarship is doing.

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What we actually have

Start with Paul. The letters of the Apostle Paul to the churches in Corinth, Rome, Galatia and elsewhere are the earliest Christian documents that survive. They were written, scholars agree, in the 50s ce—within a generation of the supposed crucifixion, and fifteen to twenty years before any of the Gospels were composed.

If you sat down expecting Paul to tell you about Jesus—the man, the teacher, the movement leader—you would be surprised. Paul never mentions the place of Jesus's birth. He never mentions his mother or father by name. He does not describe a single parable, miracle, or public confrontation. He does not say where the crucifixion happened. He does not identify Pilate. He does not identify Judas as a betrayer. He does not mention Mary Magdalene, or Peter's denial, or the Last Supper (except as a liturgical event received "from the Lord"), or any of the narrative material that fills the Gospels.

What Paul describes, over and over, is a cosmic figure known to him and his communities through revelation (*apokalypsis*, in Greek) and through the Hebrew scriptures read as encoded prophecy. "I did not receive it from a human source," Paul writes in Galatians, "nor was I taught it, but I received it through a revelation of Jesus Christ."

The single clearest biographical-sounding phrase in Paul's entire corpus is four words in his letter to the Galatians: *adelphos tou kyriou*, "brother of the Lord," used of a man named James in Jerusalem whom Paul says he met. That phrase has carried enormous weight in modern scholarship. Ehrman has called it, essentially by itself, decisive evidence for the historicity of Jesus: if Jesus had a biological brother whom Paul met, Jesus existed.

I agree the phrase is real. What I argue in my paper is that "brother" in Paul's Greek overwhelmingly does not mean biological sibling. Of the 121 times Paul uses the word *adelphos* and its variants, 117 refer to fellow members of the early Christian community—the "brothers in Christ" usage any reader of Paul's letters will recognize. Zero of the remaining occurrences unambiguously denote a biological brother of anyone. Which raises a question: if "brother" in Paul's corpus is overwhelmingly a community term, why is the single phrase "brother of the Lord" being translated as a kinship claim rather than as a community title?

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A number nobody had calculated

This is where my paper does something that, to my knowledge, no one had done before. I compiled a statistical sample of how the word *adelphos* is actually used in Greek-language texts from the two centuries surrounding Paul's lifetime—ancient letters scrawled on papyrus, the Greek translation of the Hebrew Bible, the writings of Philo of Alexandria, the works of Josephus, Plutarch, Epictetus, Polybius, Strabo, Diodorus. I drew 405 random tokens, classified each one, and computed the base rate for a "community of fellow members" usage.

The rate is 0.7 percent. Paul's rate is 96.7 percent.

This extreme difference is not, as such, a proof of anything. I am careful in the paper to note that my sample excludes a relevant register: Greek inscriptions from religious associations across the eastern Mediterranean, where the word *adelphoi* was the normal term for fellow members of cult societies. A scholar named Philip Harland documented these inscriptions in a 2005 article. Among them are nine dedications to a deity called Theos Hypsistos at a Greek-Iranian frontier town called Tanais, where members of the association called themselves, formulaically, "adopted brothers who revere Theos Hypsistos"—structurally identical to Paul's "brothers of the Lord."

Factoring the inscriptional evidence in, the gap between Paul and the ambient baseline shrinks. But the interpretive consequence runs the opposite direction from what a defender of Jesus's historicity would like. Far from isolating Paul as an idiosyncratic stylist, the inscriptions show that Paul was writing in a well-attested Greek register in which *adelphoi* of a patron figure was a normal community designation. The more natural reading of "brother of the Lord," when placed in its actual Greek religious-associative context, is that it names

James as a member of a group within the Pauline movement, not as the biological sibling of a historical Galilean.

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What the Gospels can and cannot show

The Gospels—Mark, Matthew, Luke, John—present a different problem. They were written between 40 and 70 years after the supposed events, by authors whose identities we do not know, in Greek, for audiences that were not in Palestine. None of them claims to be an eyewitness account.

Biblical scholarship has for more than a century recognized that the narrative details of the Gospels are, to a strong degree, constructed from Hebrew Bible templates. The passion narrative of Mark maps, verse by verse, onto Psalm 22 ("My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?"), Isaiah 53 ("he was numbered with the transgressors"), the Wisdom of Solomon 2–5, and Zechariah. The ministry reprises the Elijah-Elisha miracle cycle. The birth narratives are transparently built from proof-texts, and Matthew's and Luke's birth narratives contradict each other so sharply that they cannot both be historical.

I want to concede something here that some mythicist writing has missed. Demonstrating that a narrative is constructed from scriptural templates does not on its own prove that no subject underlies it. Historical figures have been described through scriptural grammars in antiquity—the biographies of the Maccabean heroes are a case in point. What the Gospel material shows is not the non-existence of a historical Jesus, but that the Gospels cannot be used as independent testimony for his existence. The question of historicity then has to be decided on other evidence.

That other evidence turns out to be thin. Josephus, writing in the 90s ce, has two passages mentioning Jesus. The longer one, the *Testimonium Flavianum*, is almost universally agreed to have been tampered with by later Christian copyists; how much of it is original is contested. The shorter James passage is accepted as largely genuine, but the phrase Josephus uses— "brother of Jesus called Christ"—may itself be a later insertion, and in any case carries limited evidential weight almost a century after the supposed events, from an author writing in Rome for a Roman audience who probably learned what he knew from the Christian communities he encountered.

Tacitus, writing around 116 ce, mentions Christ's execution by Pilate, but almost certainly draws his information from Christian informants rather than from Roman imperial records. The rabbinic traditions about Yeshu, including the later *Toledot Yeshu* compilations, are polemical engagements with the Christian narrative, not independent attestations of an earlier figure.

What would settle the question is the kind of evidence that settled the historicity of Pilate

himself: a first-century inscription, a contemporary document, an artefact naming him. No such object has ever been found. The 2002 "James Ossuary"—which briefly looked like it might be such an artefact—was found by an Israeli antiquities investigation to bear a modern forgery.

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The honest concessions

I have tried, in writing the paper, to be explicit about the places where my own argument is difficult to defend. Three Pauline passages in particular are, in my assessment, "genuine challenges."

Romans 1:3 describes Christ as "descended from David according to the flesh"—a specifically genealogical, specifically historical, specifically Jewish-messianic claim. Galatians 4:4 says Christ was "born of a woman, born under the law." And the witness list in 1 Corinthians 15 names specific people—Cephas, James, the Twelve, five hundred brothers at once, Paul himself—to whom the risen Christ is said to have appeared.

These are not easy passages for a purely mythic reading. I engage each of them and offer possible readings (they are pre-Pauline creedal formulas; "according to the flesh" can mark a descent into the sublunar realm of flesh rather than a biographical lineage; the witness list reads less like a biographical record than like a list of visionary recipients), but I do not claim to have fully resolved them. The concluding chapter is explicit: several features of the evidence pose genuine difficulties for the mythic-origin model that have not been fully resolved.

What I have tried to offer, alongside the critique, is a constructive hypothesis. Drawing on the 1941 work of Gershom Scholem on Jewish mysticism and the more recent work of Alan Segal on Paul as a visionary-mystic, I argue that the earliest Christian community looks exactly like a Second Temple Jewish apocalyptic- mystical sect that generated its knowledge of a heavenly mediator figure through the well-attested procedures of visionary ascent and scriptural exegesis—the same procedures that produced the *Similitudes of Enoch*, the *Apocalypse of Abraham*, the *Ascension of Isaiah*, and the Dead Sea Scrolls' Self-Glorification Hymn. The Christ Paul knew, on this reading, is a named heavenly figure known to the community by revelation. The historicization—the setting of that figure in recent Galilean time and place—comes later, with the Gospel of Mark around 70 ce.

This is much closer to the scholarly mainstream than most mythicist writing gets. It does not invoke pagan dying-and-rising mystery cults. It does not claim Paul was a Gnostic. It does not deny that Christianity is rooted in Jewish thought. It simply argues that the specific Jewish thought-world it is rooted in—visionary-ascent apocalypticism—does not require a historical founder to explain what the early letters say.

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What the field has not been asking

I am not the first person to make parts of this argument. What I have tried to do differently is handle the argument's own weaknesses honestly. I list by name the scholars whose work most threatens my conclusions—Dale Allison of Princeton Theological Seminary, Paula Fredriksen of Boston University, Matthew Novenson of Edinburgh, Philip Harland of York University—and I walk through what each of them would likely say in response. A companion document in the repository anticipates the reviewer objections the paper is most likely to draw.

The question, as I put it in the paper's methodological preface, is not whether scholars agree. The question is whether the evidence warrants their agreement.

That framing may be the most provocative thing in the document. The scholarly study of the historical Jesus emerged, historically, from within divinity schools and confessional faculties. Even the field's most rigorous critics—Bart Ehrman, who is an agnostic; Gerd Theissen, a sociologist; John Dominic Crossan, a former priest—came up through institutions in which the existence of Jesus was a shared premise of the enterprise. The field has been intensely rigorous about almost every other aspect of the tradition: about which sayings are authentic, about the Synoptic problem, about textual transmission, about the development of doctrine. What it has not, as a field, been in the habit of asking is whether its shared starting premise holds.

I do not expect a single paper to settle that question. I am not asking for it to be settled. I am asking for it to be examined with the same tools the field uses to examine everything else.

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The stakes

None of what I argue undermines the cultural, theological, or ethical significance of the Christian tradition. A figure assembled from Jewish scripture and Hellenistic religious imagination is not less philosophically consequential than a figure assembled from oral memory and community tradition. The Sermon on the Mount is what it is regardless of whether it was spoken on a hillside or composed in a community in Antioch.

What is at stake is not theology. What is at stake is what the discipline of history looks like when it applies its own evidentiary standards consistently.

Near the end of the paper I wrote a line that reads less like an argument than like a challenge: if the field cannot bring itself to treat the question as open—if the mere posing of the question continues to be treated as a mark of incompetence rather than as a legitimate

scholarly inquiry—then the field has a problem that no amount of consensus can resolve.

Ehrman, for what it is worth, is unlikely to change his mind. Dale Allison is more likely to engage. Paula Fredriksen will probably not be persuaded but may push my argument in productive directions. Philip Harland, the specialist on *adelphoi* in Greek religious associations, is the scholar whose work is most directly cited in my paper, and whose reaction will be most informative, if he chooses to respond.

Whether any of them does is the real test. For two thousand years, the question of whether Jesus of Nazareth existed has been answered with a confidence that the evidence itself does not quite support. I have written an 85-page paper asking the field to notice.

The paper and supplementary materials are available at `https://github.com/sbthomas/historicity` *under a Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial licence. The full-length paper runs to 86 pages; a journal-length compressed version and two technical supplements (a Greek-text supplement with every adelph- occurrence in the authentic Pauline letters colour-coded by classification, and a corpus-linguistic baseline establishing the cross-corpus rate of community-sense adelphos in contemporary non-Christian Greek) accompany the main document.*